candidates and media pundits debate these issues. On Facebook, friends posted links to videos defending and decrying anti-Muslim sentiments. I was reminded of other times when similar exchanges have occurred: "It's not condemning people, it's ideas," a media personality defended his claims about Islam in a televised debate, in which he, other pundits, and a popular film actor exchanged heated views about whether Islam was inherently violent (HBO 2014). The actor had accused the others in the debate of making racist arguments and stereotyping all Muslims; they had relied on sweeping generalizations about Islam, illustrated through references to despicable acts by groups like the Islamic State (Islamic State of Iraq and Syria, ISIS). The video of this debate had been circulating widely in October 2014, almost exactly one year before election campaigning had begun in earnest in either Myanmar or the US, and as I watched it sitting in my apartment in Yangon, the parallels to things I heard in Myanmar were striking. The next morning in the teashop, I sat discussing the news with friends from the neighbourhood in which I lived, two brothers and a third man from their block. One of the brothers looked at me with concern: "Can I ask you about something?" He wanted to talk about ISIS. "They are so horrible", he said. "Why is the US military not making war on them?"

I also think ISIS is horrible, I told him, and I explained that I thought many people in my country were tired of war. I offered my opinions about the effectiveness of US military interventions. This conversation was one of many in an ongoing discussion we had over the years I was living in his neighbourhood. I spent considerable time sitting in teashops and on the corner, talking with him, his brothers, and others in the township about a variety of issues. History, politics, and religion were frequent topics, along with many others more quotidian. In early 2013, I began taking note of debates about Buddhist–Muslim violence, when conversations in the neighbourhood were increasingly turning to what my friends felt to be serious dangers from Islam. Our conversation that morning in October was specific to threats from ISIS; over the years, I had heard this brother and our other friends make a persistent set of arguments about Islam in general, and Muslims in Myanmar, characterized as inherently violent and a threat. These arguments seemed to echo — or were echoed in — the posts I was seeing on social media from back home in the US. These narratives were also making people worry within the Myanmar civil society networks where I was working at the time, prompting notable campaigns calling for peace between religious communities.